



# Muncie Fire Merit Commission March 12, 2026

| Meeting Metadata | Details                                                                                               |
|------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Video Recording  | <a href="https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=CVOPIEanKv4">https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=CVOPIEanKv4</a> |
| Publication Date | 2026-03-12T22:14:00Z                                                                                  |
| Target Category  | muncie_city                                                                                           |

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## Meeting Summary Report

### 2. Meeting Identification & Attendance

- **Call to Order & Spoken Details:** Presiding Officer Andrew Dale called the regular monthly meeting of the Muncie Fire Merit Commission to order at 6:00 PM on March 12th.
- **Attendance:**
  - **Present:** Victoria Rose, Andrew Dale (President), Linda Gray, Mike White, Chief Berford, and Mark Urban (Legal Counsel). Commissioner Kevin Kohley participated remotely via video.
  - **Absent:** None noted.
  - **Presiding Officer:** Andrew Dale.

### 3. Preliminary & Procedural Business

- **Ceremonial Openings:** None noted in the transcript.
- **Approval of Minutes:** [00:01:28](#) The minutes from the previous meeting on February 12th were presented, reviewed, and **Approved by Voice Vote**.

### 4. Substantive Business & Board Action

[00:02:26](#) Fire Chief's Report: Probationary Evaluations & Promotional Testing Rubric

- **Sponsor / Presenter:** Chief Berford.
- **Deliberation Summary:**
  - Chief Berford reported that probationary firefighters Eric Jordan, Ryan Parton, and Bryce Winningham received positive nine-month evaluations, noting they are progressing nicely and improving every quarter.
  - The Chief presented a newly developed skills examination and rubric for the driver-operator and sergeants promotional testing, created in coordination with Training Division/Chief Investigator Grindstaff and Commissioner Whited. The test is graded on a pass/fail basis requiring seven points to pass, with specific “critical fails” established for mandatory duties.
  - Additionally, the Chief highlighted the department’s training achievements, noting nearly 2,000 classroom hours equating to well over 30,000 educational hours over the past year.
- **Item-Specific Public Input:** None.
- **Action & Vote Disposition:** 00:05:06 Motion to accept the testing rubric and report **Approved by Voice Vote.**

#### 00:06:32 Legal Counsel Update: Firefighter Benjamin Rens Circuit Court Remand

- **Sponsor / Presenter:** Mark Urban, Legal Counsel.
- **Deliberation Summary:**
  - Legal Counsel Mark Urban updated the commission regarding a court appeal filed by firefighter Benjamin Rens in the Delaware County Circuit Court (Cause No. 1842-2405-PL-0053).
  - An order entered by Judge Fe on February 18th remanded the disciplinary matter back to the Merit Commission for further consideration. The judge raised two primary concerns: whether a proper investigation was conducted and whether the initial complaint was verified by a notary.
  - The department filed two corresponding documents for the commission’s review: an affirmation of disciplinary complaint and a summary of investigation.
- **Item-Specific Public Input:** None.
- **Action & Vote Disposition:** 00:10:16 A motion was made and seconded to take the received information and court order under consideration for future action as the merit commission deems appropriate. **Passed 4-0** via roll call vote (Commissioner Kohley abstained/did not vote due to remote connection requirements; affirmative votes recorded from Victoria Rose, Andrew Dale, Linda Gray, and Mike White).

## 5. Open Public Comment / Citizen Forum

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- 00:11:21 **Unnamed Resident / Union Representative:** Spoke briefly during the public comment period to remark on the low public attendance, drawing a parallel to union

meetings where low attendance often indicates that things are running smoothly, and thanked the commission for their service.

## 6. Administrative Updates & Adjournment

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- **Staff / Board Announcements:** None.
- **Adjournment:** 00:11:42 A motion to adjourn was made and seconded, and the meeting was concluded.

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